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IT IS A COUNTRY WHERE DIFFERENCES
ARE ITS STRONGEST SAFEGUARDS
AGAINST BREAKING UP

BY MANIL SURI

Some years ago, I spent a summer in Finland, working at the Helsinki University of Technology. The Finns are a remarkably orderly people—calm, low-key and well-behaved. Lunch at the university cafeteria was invariably a rather sedate affair—people quietly going about their business (which happened, at the moment, to be the ingestion of food) and only speaking when spoken to. This hour of silence every afternoon (broken only by the soft sound of chewing) became so unnerving that I started trying to stir up some excitement. I began soliciting the opinions of my co-workers on the most controversial social topics I could think of—religion, politics, race, abortion, sexuality—to see if I could strike a nerve, stumble onto differences in belief between them strong enough to provoke an argument.

What I found was that for each question, only a single person would stop eating to answer—succinctly stating the prevailing national position, while the rest nodded in agreement. There were no differences in opinion—the lunch group (and by extension the rest of the country) was reacting as a single entity, a multi-headed organism which not only responded with a unified voice, but also somehow knew whom to pick next for the role of mouthpiece. I became so obsessed with trying to find something contentious that I started doing my homework—digging up prickly questions like the country's problems with alcoholism, or reservation quotas for the small (5.5 per cent) Swedish-speaking minority. But the re-

sponse remained the same. My fantasy of Finn vs. Finn never came to fruition—they were much too homogeneous a group. An entire nation of five million bound together with essentially the same beliefs, customs, culture, language—they even look the same. What unites Finland? Everything does.

India, of course, is the exact antithesis—examining the population, one uncovers only differences. The various divisions in terms of class and culture, religion and language, caste and sub-caste, skin tone and physical characteristics, offer a well-stocked boutique of reasons to discriminate against each other. Applying the Finnish model suggests that we should all, like an aggre-